

AROUSAL PATTERNS

NURS 280 MAY 21, 2026



HUMAN SEXUAL RESPONSE CYCLE*

* the sequence of changes that take place in the body during arousal

- First studied and written about by **William Masters & Virginia Johnson** in the **1960s**
- Based on observation of sexual response in **laboratory setting**
- Recorded physiological data when their research subjects self-pleasured, or were paired up and then observed during sex
- M&J divided the sexual response cycle into four phases: **excitement, plateau, orgasm, resolution**



FOUR STAGE MODEL OF SEXUAL RESPONSE

1. Excitement:

- heart rate, breathing, blood pressure rise
- **vasocongestion** and erections (clitoris, penis, nipples...)
- testicles draw upwards
- vaginas lubricate



FOUR STAGE MODEL OF SEXUAL RESPONSE

2. Plateau:

- pleasure
- increased muscle tension, rapid breathing and heart rate
- sex flush
- pre-ejaculate released
- clitoris very sensitive
- vagina lengthens (“**tenting**”)



FOUR STAGE MODEL OF SEXUAL RESPONSE

3. Orgasm

- quick muscle contractions & spasms
- blood pressure, heart rate, and respiration peak
- euphoric sensations
- ejaculation (perhaps)
- feeling of release



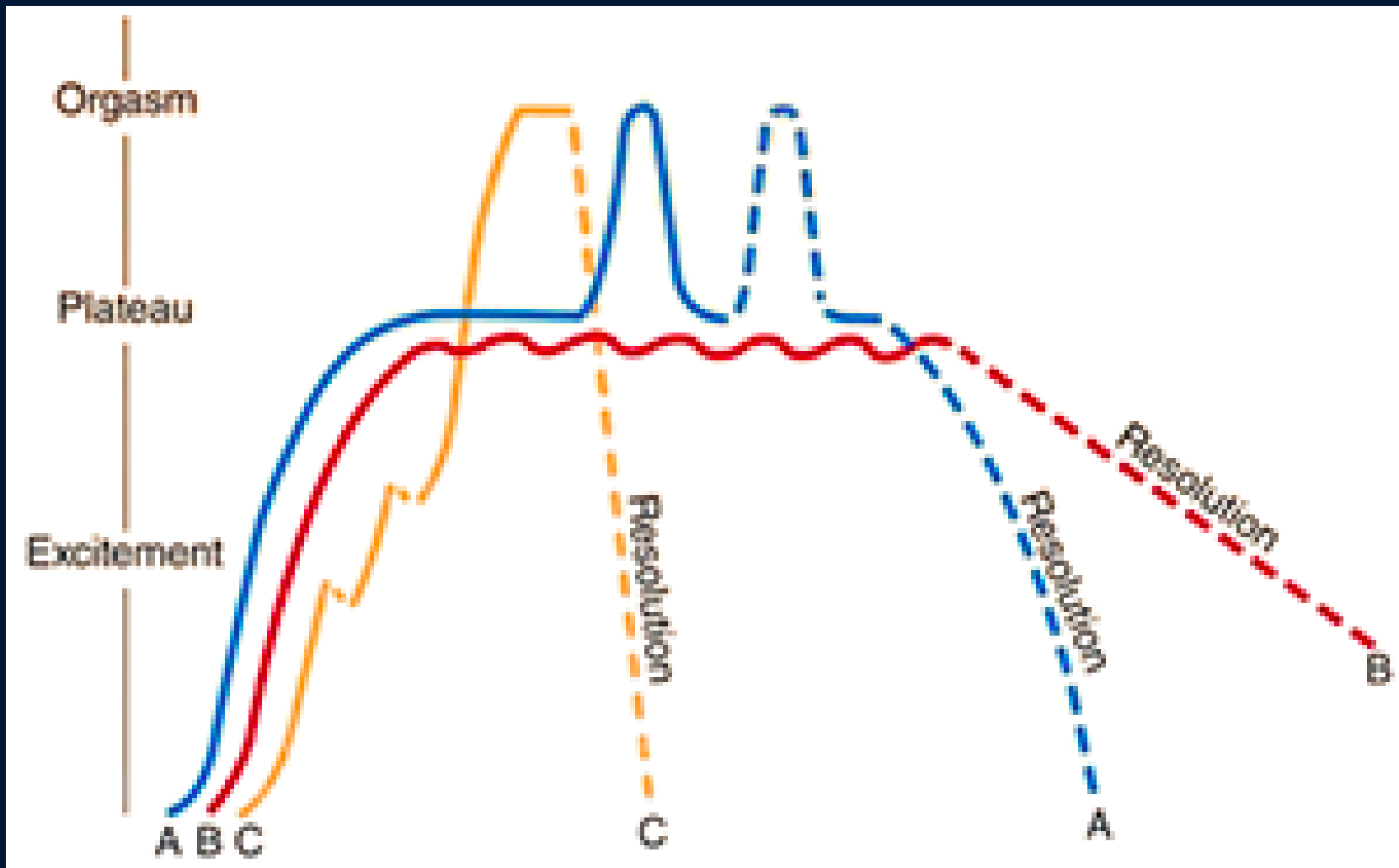
FOUR STAGE MODEL OF SEXUAL RESPONSE

4. Resolution

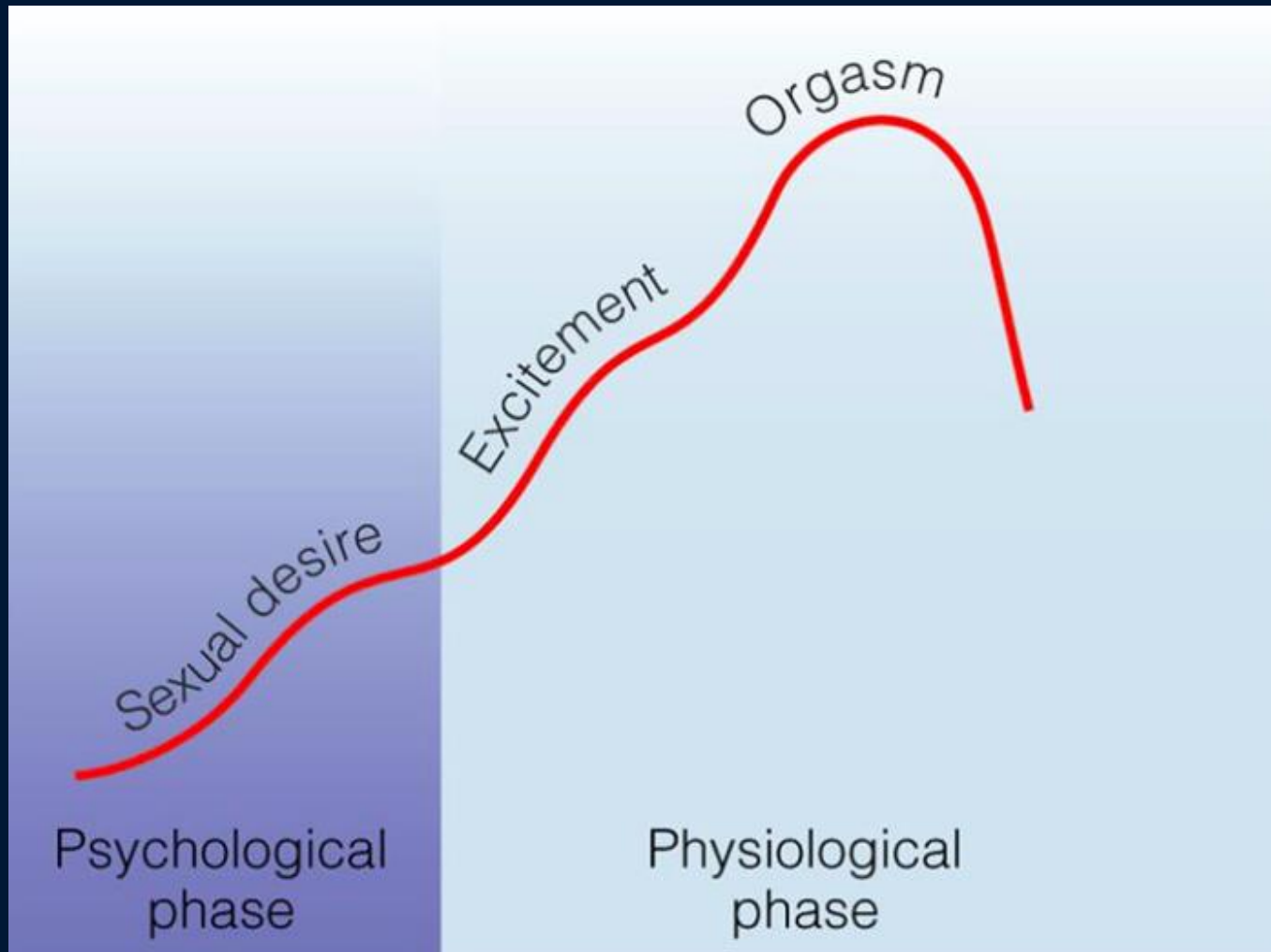
- body slows, relaxes
- release of blood from engorged areas
- penis becomes flaccid (**refractory period**)
- clitoris extremely sensitive (additional orgasms may be possible)



M&J FOUR STAGE MODEL OF SEXUAL RESPONSE

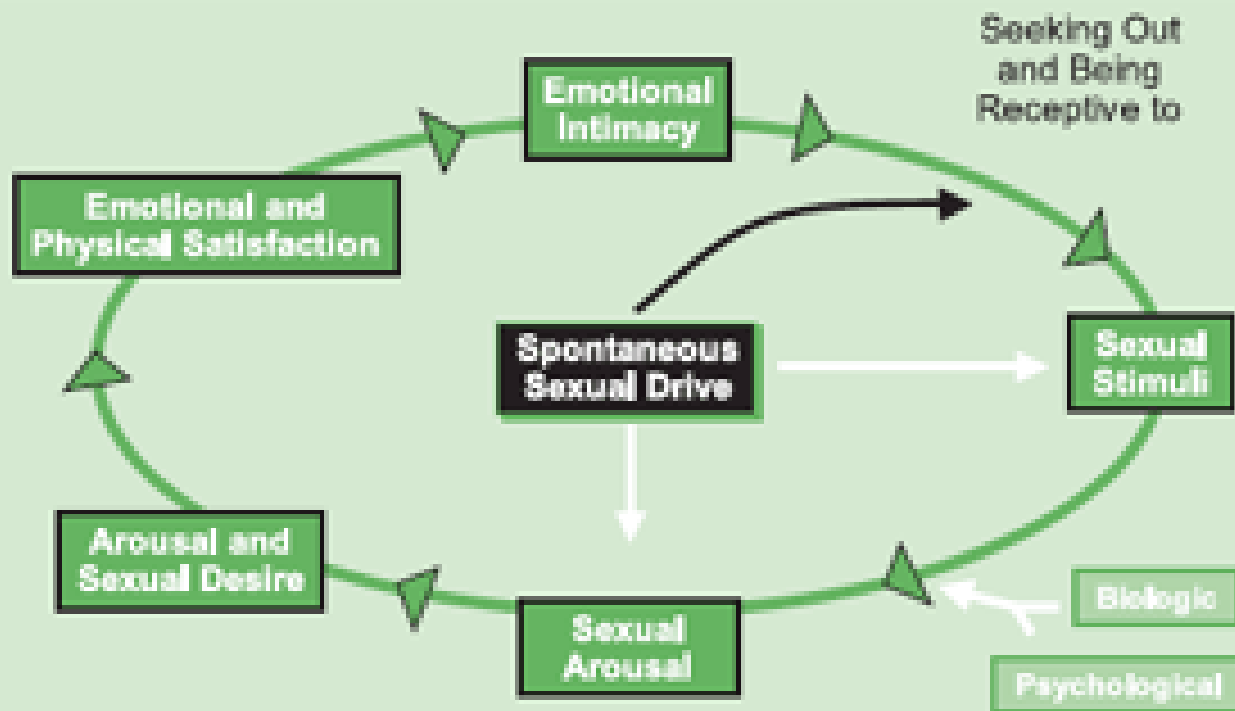


HELEN SINGER KAPLAN'S THREE STAGES OF SEXUAL RESPONSE (1974)



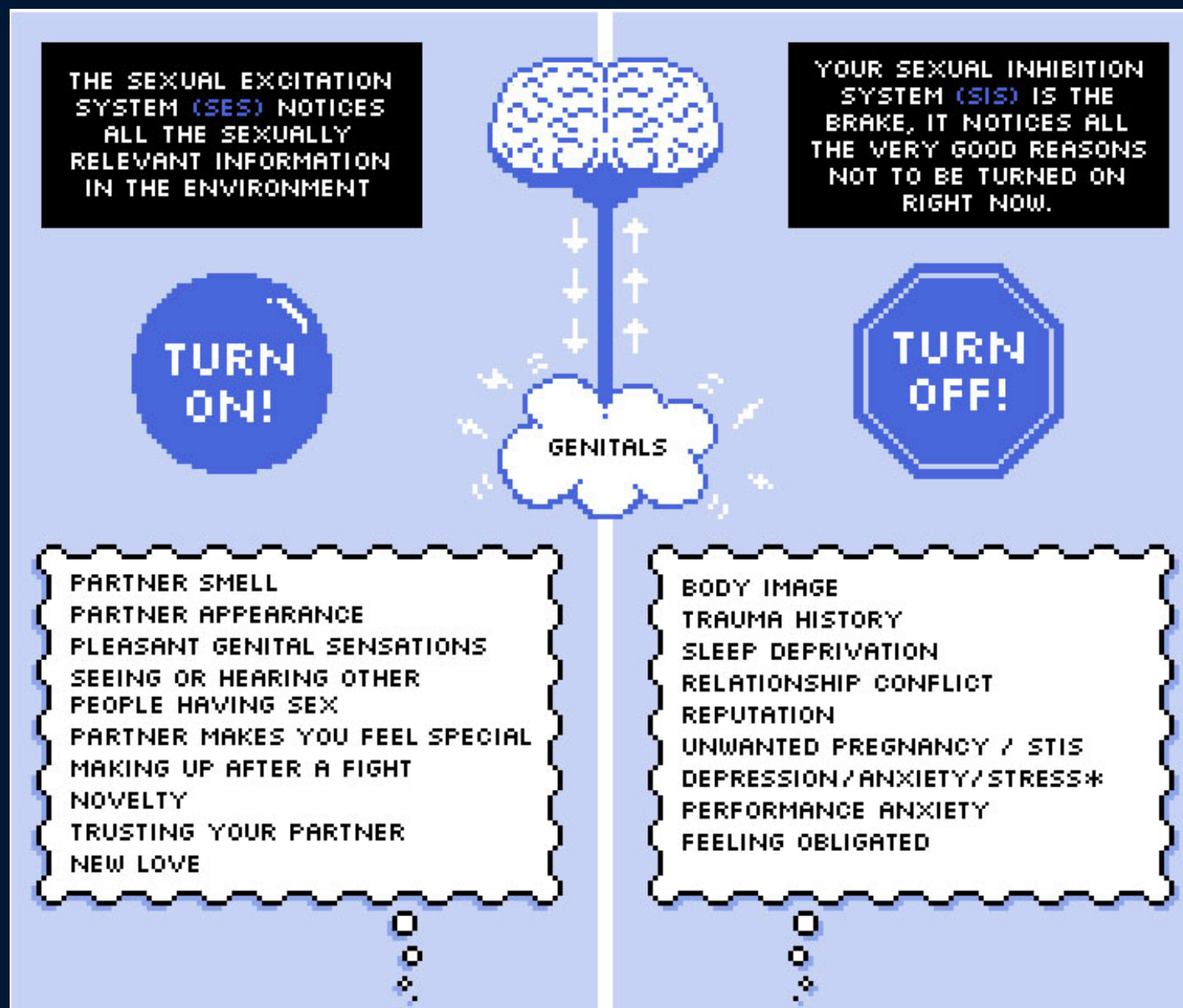
ROSEMARY BASSON'S INTIMACY MODEL OF FEMALE SEXUAL RESPONSE (2008)

FIGURE 3. Non-linear Model of Female Sexual Response
Developed by Basson⁶



Basson's non-linear model acknowledges how emotional intimacy, sexual stimuli, and relationship satisfaction affect female sexual response.

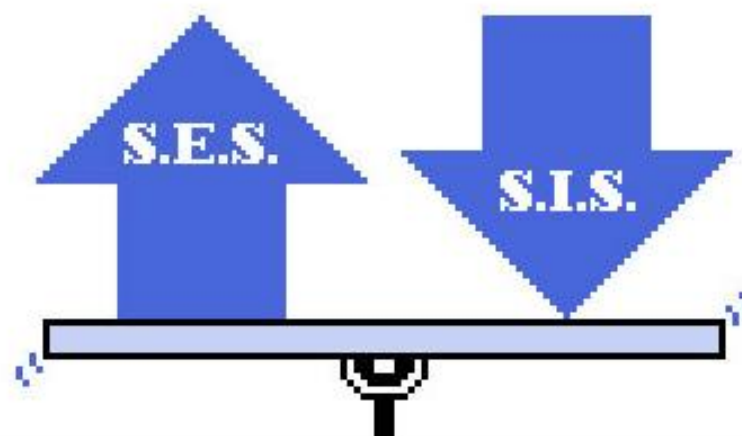
THE DUAL CONTROL MODEL (BANCROFT & JANSSEN, 2000)



THE PROCESS OF BECOMING AROUSED IS THE PROCESS OF TURNING **ON** THE ONS AND TURNING **OFF** THE OFFS.



YOUR LEVEL OF AROUSAL AT ANY MOMENT IS THE BALANCE OF YOUR BRAKES AND GAS-



MOST PEOPLE THINK THAT DIFFICULTIES WITH DESIRE AND AROUSAL CAN BE SOLVED BY ADDING MORE STIMULATION TO THE GAS PEDAL.

RESEARCH HAS SHOWN THAT IT'S MUCH MORE LIKELY YOU NEED LESS ACTIVATION TO THE BRAKES.

COSTUMES

DONUTS

TOYS

APHRODISIACS

PHARMACEUTICALS

ROLE PLAY

ROMANCE

EROTICA



SLEEP

NO-STRINGS AFFECTION

TRUST

DONUTS

A GOOD CRY

RELAXATION

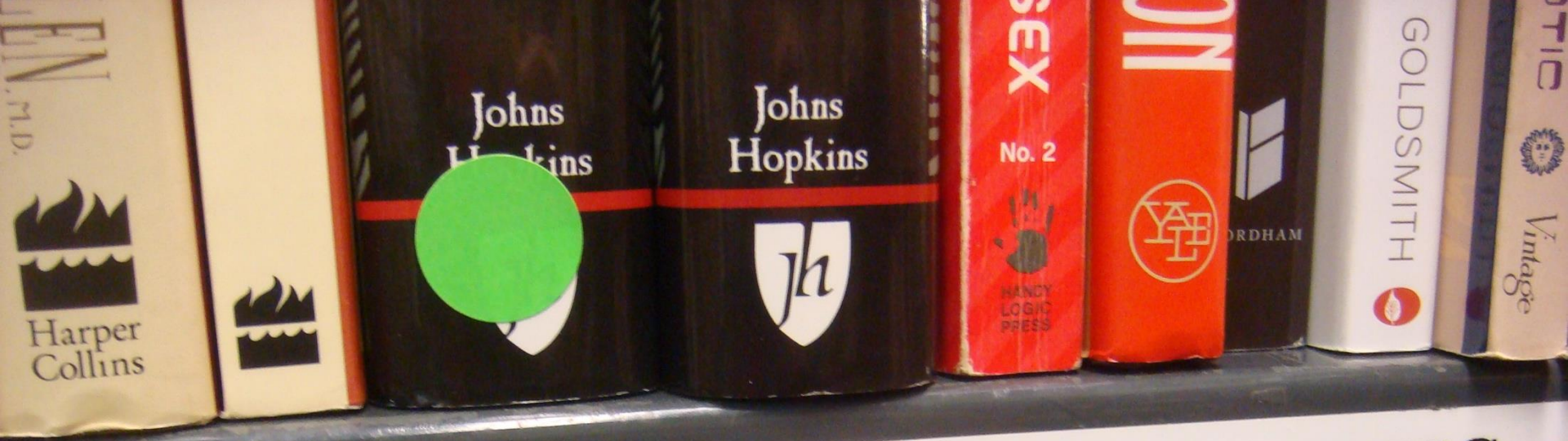
YOGA

PHYSICAL ACTIVITY

THE TRUTH ABOUT UNWANTED AROUSAL
DR. EMILY NAGOSKI



EMILY **NAGOSKI**



SEXUALITY CONTINUES



THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

